

Beyond Identity and Organizationality: Viability as a Distinct Ontological Problem in Organization Theory

Abstract

Organization theory has developed sophisticated explanations of how organizations vary, adapt, and perform, yet it has paid comparatively less explicit attention to what must be sustained for organizations to persist as organizations over time. This paper argues that the field has under-specified a distinct ontological problem of persistence: viability. Existing conversations have clarified what organizations are and when collective arrangements count as organizational, but they have less clearly isolated the conditions required for continued organized existence. To address this gap, the paper distinguishes ontologies of identity from ontologies of viability and develops a structural account of viability grounded in a criterion of necessity. On this basis, it derives three minimal conditions of organizational persistence: temporal orientation, structured coordination, and operational enactment. It then argues that, because these conditions must be continuously sustained, viability implies reproduction over time, which in turn points toward a grammatical layer concerned with the patterned organization of that reproduction. By distinguishing viability as a distinct ontological problem, the paper sharpens the difference between organizational functioning and organizational persistence, provides a lower-bound basis for comparison across heterogeneous organizational forms, and opens a research agenda on fragility, erosion, collapse, and the grammar of organizational reproduction.

Keywords: grammar; ontology; organizational persistence; organizationality; viability.

1. Introduction

Organization theory has developed increasingly sophisticated explanations of how organizations vary, adapt, stabilize, and change. Across major traditions, scholars have shown how organizations respond to environmental contingencies, construct and sustain meaning, coordinate distributed activity, secure legitimacy, and generate heterogeneous outcomes over time (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967; Scott, 2003; Weick, Sutcliffe, & Obstfeld, 2005). Yet one question remains less clearly specified than the maturity of the field might suggest: what must be sustained for organizations to persist as organizations over time?

This question matters because much of organization theory proceeds by presupposing the continued existence of the very phenomenon it seeks to explain. The field has become highly effective at theorizing variation—why organizations differ, how they function under different conditions, why they succeed or fail, and how they relate to their environments—but has paid comparatively less explicit attention to the minimal conditions under which organized collective existence is maintained in the first place (Scott, 2003; Davis, 2010). As a result, organizational persistence is often inferred from activity, performance, formal status, or recognizability rather than specified as a problem in its own right.

This omission is not a sign of theoretical weakness. It reflects the field's historical development. Organization theory has advanced by refining local explanatory problems—adaptation, coordination, legitimacy, routines, identity, institutionalization, and change—thereby producing a plural landscape in which different traditions illuminate different dimensions of organizational life (Scott, 2003; Davis, 2010). But this success has also encouraged a tacit division of labor in which the existence of the organization is often treated as already given. The result is a metatheoretical asymmetry: while the field offers

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sophisticated explanations of how organizations operate and vary, it less often specifies what must structurally be in place for them to endure as organized collectivities at all.

Recent work has brought renewed attention to ontological questions in organization theory. Scholars have revisited what organizations are, how they are constituted, and under what conditions collective arrangements come to count as organizational phenomena. Research on organizational identity has clarified how organizations become recognizable and continuous as social entities; work on organizationality has examined how fluid or partial collectives acquire organizational character; and recent ontological discussions have explicitly interrogated what it means for organizations to “exist” (Dobusch & Schoeneborn, 2015; Azevedo, 2024). Yet these advances also reveal a persistent analytical slippage between two different questions: what organizations are and what must be sustained for them to remain organizational over time.

This paper argues that these questions should not be conflated. Organization theory has developed increasingly refined ways of asking what organizations are and when collective arrangements count as organizational. What remains less clearly distinguished is a further ontological question concerning organizational persistence: what conditions must be continuously sustained for an organization to continue existing as an organization? We refer to this question as the problem of viability. Viability, as developed here, does not refer to performance, success, adaptation, or survival in a merely descriptive sense. Nor is it reducible to identity, legitimacy, or organizational recognition. Rather, it concerns the conditions of continued organized existence: the structural requirements without which a collective can no longer be said to persist as an organization over time.

The central claim of the paper is straightforward but consequential: organization theory has under-specified viability as a distinct ontological problem. Without such a

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distinction, the field lacks a clear basis for separating variation in organizational form, dysfunction within an organization, and the erosion of the conditions required for organizational persistence itself. In turn, it becomes difficult to distinguish a weak organization from a collective that may no longer sustain the conditions of organizational existence at all. That is not a minor conceptual gap. It limits what organization theory can diagnose and compare.

To address this problem, the paper introduces a distinction between ontologies of identity and ontologies of viability. Ontologies of identity address what organizations are: how they are constituted, recognized, narrated, and rendered meaningful as social entities. Ontologies of viability, by contrast, address what must be sustained for organizations to persist through time as organized collectivities. The argument is not that existing ontological approaches are mistaken on their own terms. It is that they do not exhaust the ontological question. A distinct level of inquiry remains under-theorized: the level at which persistence itself becomes the object of specification.

From this distinction, the paper develops a structural ontology of viability. Its guiding premise is that organizational persistence cannot be treated as a brute fact. If an organization persists, then some set of conditions must be recurrently sustained such that the collective remains capable of enduring as an organized entity over time. To identify such conditions, the paper adopts a criterion of necessity: a condition counts as ontologically relevant if its sustained absence implies the collapse of the phenomenon as an organization. The paper then derives the minimal conditions required for such persistence and argues that these conditions must be continuously reproduced over time. At that point, and only at that point, it introduces grammar—not as an alternative ontology or a complete organizational system, but as the patterned reproduction of the conditions that make persistence possible.

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The paper makes four contributions. First, it identifies and names a distinct ontological problem in organization theory: viability as the problem of organizational persistence. Second, it distinguishes ontologies of identity from ontologies of viability, thereby clarifying a recurrent source of analytical conflation in the field. Third, it develops a structural account of viability grounded in a criterion of necessity and derives the minimal conditions required for organizational persistence. Fourth, it shows why the temporal reproduction of those conditions points toward a grammatical layer of analysis concerned with how persistence is recurrently sustained.

These contributions matter not only philosophically, but also for theory building. Theoretical contributions become stronger when they clarify a problem that existing concepts only partially capture and show why the distinction changes what can be seen and explained (Cornelissen & Durand, 2014). Distinguishing viability does precisely that. It provides a more explicit baseline for comparing theoretical traditions without collapsing them into one another and clarifies the difference between organizational functioning and organizational persistence.

The paper proceeds as follows. The next section reviews existing conversations in organization theory concerning identity, organizationality, and ontology. It then argues that these conversations bring the field close to, but do not clearly isolate, the problem of viability. The paper next distinguishes viability from identity, performance, survival, and legitimacy, develops a structural ontology of viability grounded in conditions of existence and necessity, derives the minimal conditions of organizational persistence, and shows why those conditions point toward a grammatical layer of analysis. The final sections discuss the implications of this argument, delimit its scope, and specify the conditions under which it could be challenged.

If organization theory has long asked what organizations are and how they behave, this paper asks a prior question: what must structurally be sustained for organizations to continue being at all?

2. Existing Conversations: Identity, Organizationality, and the Ontological Question

2.1 Identity

A major line of inquiry in organization theory has approached the ontological question through identity. In this register, the central issue is not only whether organizations exist, but how they become recognizable, intelligible, and continuous as social entities. Identity-oriented work has shown that organizations are not exhausted by formal structure or technical arrangement; they are also constituted through self-description, shared interpretation, and symbolic stabilization (Albert & Whetten, 1985; Chreim, 2005; He & Brown, 2013). Organizations endure, in part, because they are narratively and socially maintained as coherent collectivities.

This literature has been especially important in demonstrating that organizational continuity is not reducible to structural sameness. Organizations may change membership, activities, or form while remaining recognizable as the “same” organization because some thread of self-definition is preserved. In that sense, identity research has clarified how continuity can be symbolically and interpretively sustained under conditions of change. More recent work has also reinforced the ontological relevance of this perspective by examining how organizations are rendered meaningful as entities through shared conventions, institutionalized understandings, and stabilizing claims about what kind of collective is at stake (Azevedo, 2024; Robinson & Atanasova, 2025).

Yet identity-centered approaches remain oriented primarily toward the question of what organizations are. Their core achievement lies in explaining how organizations become

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meaningful, recognizable, and narratively continuous as social entities. What they do not fully specify is the distinct question of what must be sustained for those entities to continue existing as organizations over time. Even when identity scholarship addresses continuity, the continuity in question is generally symbolic or self-definitional. The problem pursued here is narrower and more structural: not how organizations remain recognizable, but what conditions must be maintained for organized existence itself to persist.

2.2 Organizationality

If identity research focuses on what organizations are, research on organizationality moves closer to a threshold problem: when does a collective arrangement count as organizational at all? This shift is important because it relaxes the assumption that organizations must appear as fully stabilized, bounded, and formalized entities in order to qualify as objects of analysis. Instead, organizationality directs attention to fluid, partial, emergent, or contested forms of organizing and asks under what conditions such forms acquire sufficient organizational character to be treated as organizations (Dobusch & Schoeneborn, 2015).

This perspective has sharpened the field's sensitivity to forms of organizing that sit at the margins of the conventional organization: loosely coupled networks, temporary initiatives, movements, and collectivities with unstable boundaries or authority structures. Rather than beginning from the premise that organizations are self-evident units, organizationality asks when the threshold of the organizational has been crossed. In doing so, it clarifies that not every instance of coordinated collective activity constitutes an organization. Something more than interaction or repeated cooperation is required for a collective arrangement to count as organizational in the first place.

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For the present argument, this conversation is especially important because it comes closer than identity to the question of persistence. Organizationality explicitly problematizes the presupposition that the organization is already given. But its primary focus remains the threshold of becoming organizational, not the conditions of remaining organizational over time. A collective may acquire organizational character in the present without thereby clarifying what must be sustained for that character to persist. Put differently, organizationality addresses organizational emergence or status; it does not, by itself, specify the structural requirements of continued organizational existence.

This distinction is subtle but important. Organizationality asks when something counts as organizational. The present paper asks what must be sustained for it to continue being so. In that sense, organizationality is not a rival to the argument developed here, but its closest conceptual neighbor. It brings organization theory to the edge of the present problem without yet isolating the question of persistence as a distinct ontological issue.

2.3 Ontology without Viability

Recent work has also made the ontological question itself more explicit within organization theory. Rather than leaving ontology in the background as a purely philosophical concern, these contributions have foregrounded what it means for organizations to exist, how organizational phenomena are constituted, and what deeper assumptions underwrite their intelligibility as entities (Azevedo, 2024). This is an important development because it shows that the present argument is not introducing ontology from outside the field. The field has already begun reopening the question of the organizational object at a more fundamental level.

These developments matter in two ways. First, they show that organization theory is already engaging questions of existence, constitution, and ontological status. Second, they

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make possible a more precise statement of the gap pursued here. The issue is not whether the field lacks ontological reflection. It does not. The issue is whether these ontological discussions have clearly distinguished viability as a specific problem concerning the persistence of organizations over time.

That distinction should not be assumed. Ontology, in its broader sense, can be directed toward different questions: what kind of entity an organization is, how it becomes recognizable, or when a collective arrangement counts as organizational at all. These are all genuine ontological questions. But they are not identical to the question pursued in this paper. The problem of viability is more specific: not what organizations are, nor when they count as organizations, but what must be sustained for them to remain organizations over time.

This point is easy to blur because the language of “organizational existence” can appear to include persistence by default. Yet analytically, the two should be separated. A theory may offer an account of what constitutes organizational existence without specifying the minimal structural conditions that must be continuously reproduced for that existence to endure. Likewise, a collective may be intelligible as an organization in the present while remaining unable to sustain the conditions required for continued organized existence across time. What is under-specified, then, is not ontology in general, but a particular ontological layer concerned with persistence as a condition-dependent phenomenon.

This is where the present paper locates its contribution. It does not reject identity-based, organizationality-oriented, or ontological approaches. On the contrary, it builds from them. But it argues that these conversations remain incomplete so long as they do not clearly isolate viability as a distinct problem of persistence. The next section therefore names that missing level directly and argues that organization theory needs to distinguish

viability as its own ontological problem: the problem of what must be sustained for organizations to continue being organizations over time.

3. The Missing Level: Viability as a Distinct Ontological Problem

The preceding discussion shows that organization theory has not neglected ontological questions. On the contrary, the field has developed increasingly refined ways of asking what organizations are, how they become intelligible as social entities, and when collective arrangements acquire sufficient organizational character to count as organizations at all (Scott, 2003; Dobusch & Schoeneborn, 2015; Azevedo, 2024). Yet an important problem remains insufficiently distinguished across these conversations: the problem of viability.

By viability, we do not mean performance, success, adaptation, or survival in a merely empirical sense. Nor do we mean the ability of an organization to attain its goals, retain legitimacy, or preserve a recognizable identity. These may all matter for continued organizational life, but none of them adequately specifies the ontological issue at stake here. Viability refers, more precisely, to the conditions that must be sustained for an organization to continue existing as an organization over time. It concerns not what makes organizations intelligible, nor what makes them count as organizational initially, but what makes their continued organized existence possible.

This problem is distinct because persistence introduces an analytical demand that is not resolved by constitution or recognition alone. A collective arrangement may become organizational in the present without yet clarifying the conditions under which that organizational character can be maintained. Likewise, an organization may remain intelligible to itself and to others while gradually losing the structural capacities required for its continued existence as an organized collective. In both cases, the issue is not whether the phenomenon can be named, described, or recognized, but whether the conditions that enable

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its persistence remain in place. Viability, in this sense, is the ontological problem of remaining organizational.

The distinction can be stated simply. Organizationality concerns when something becomes organizational. Viability concerns what must be sustained for it to remain organizational over time. The first addresses the threshold of organizational emergence; the second addresses the threshold of organizational endurance. Identity and organizationality therefore bring the field close to the present argument, but they do not fully resolve it. They clarify what organizations are and when collective arrangements count as organizations; they do not yet clearly specify what must be sustained for those arrangements to continue as organizations through time. Table I summarizes this distinction between identity, organizationality, viability, and grammar.

[INSERT TABLE I ABOUT HERE]

Once formulated in this way, the absence of a distinct viability layer becomes analytically consequential. Without it, organization theory risks treating persistence as an unexamined background condition of all other explanatory work. Theories may explain how organizations change, adapt, stabilize, or secure legitimacy while tacitly assuming that the organizational phenomenon itself remains in place. Yet that continued existence is not trivial. It depends on the recurrent maintenance of certain conditions, and without an explicit account of those conditions the field lacks a clear basis for distinguishing among at least three analytically different situations: variation in organizational form, dysfunction within an organization, and erosion of the conditions required for organizational existence itself.

This is where the argument bites more sharply. Without a concept of viability, organization theory is less well equipped to diagnose whether it is observing a struggling organization, a changing organization, or a collective that may no longer sustain the

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conditions of organizational persistence at all. In other words, the absence of viability as a distinct ontological category weakens the field's ability to separate poor functioning from ontological breakdown. That is why the present distinction matters not only conceptually, but also for diagnosis, comparability, and theory building.

Importantly, this argument does not claim that prior work has ignored persistence altogether. Many traditions in organization theory address persistence indirectly—through adaptation, inertia, legitimacy, identity maintenance, institutional stabilization, and processual continuity (Scott, 2003; Tsoukas & Chia, 2002). The claim is narrower and more precise: persistence has not been sufficiently distinguished as its own ontological problem. The issue is not whether scholars have studied endurance, but whether the field has clearly isolated what must be continuously sustained for organizations to endure as organizations, rather than merely as named entities, legal forms, or ongoing streams of activity.

Framing the problem this way also avoids overclaim. The contribution of this paper is not to suggest that organization theory lacks ontology, nor to announce that it has overlooked the organization itself. It is to identify a missing level within an already developing ontological conversation. Viability is not external to identity or organizationality, but neither is it reducible to them. It occupies the space between the threshold of becoming organizational and the problem of how organizational persistence is reproduced over time.

That final point is critical because it clarifies the downstream significance of the argument. If viability concerns what must be sustained for organizations to persist, then identifying viability conditions immediately raises a further question: how are those conditions reproduced over time? That question points beyond ontology toward functioning, and from functioning toward grammar. But grammar should not be introduced too early. Before one can ask how persistence is recurrently reproduced, one must first specify what

persistence requires. Viability is therefore not an optional intermediate step. It is the missing analytical level that makes the movement from organizationality to grammar theoretically coherent.

The remainder of the paper develops this claim by clarifying what viability is not, specifying its structural character, and deriving the minimal conditions required for organizational persistence. Only once those conditions are established does the analysis turn to their temporal reproduction and the grammatical implications that follow.

4. Distinguishing Viability from Identity, Performance, Survival, and Legitimacy

4.1 Viability Is Not Identity

The first distinction that requires clarification is the distinction between viability and identity. This matters because identity has provided one of organization theory's richest vocabularies for thinking about continuity. Identity research has shown how organizations become recognizable, intelligible, and narratively coherent social entities, and how they sustain claims of sameness despite change in membership, activity, or form (Albert & Whetten, 1985; Chreim, 2005; He & Brown, 2013). In that sense, identity has been central to explaining how organizations endure as meaningful collectivities.

Yet continuity of identity is not the same as continuity of organized existence. Identity concerns the question of what kind of entity the organization is and how that entity remains recognizable to itself and others. Viability concerns a different question: whether the conditions required for continued organized existence remain in place. An organization may preserve its name, self-description, symbolic repertoire, and public recognizability while losing the capacities required to persist as an organized collective over time. In such cases, identity remains legible while viability deteriorates.

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The reverse is also possible. Organizations may redefine who they are, revise their self-understanding, or shift the narrative through which they present themselves while still sustaining the conditions required for persistence. This asymmetry shows why the two concepts should not be conflated. Identity may support viability, accompany it, or help stabilize it, but it does not specify the minimal conditions without which organized existence would cease. Identity addresses continuity of who the organization is; viability addresses continuity of that it is, in the sense of sustained organized existence.

This distinction is particularly important because identity sits close to organizationality in the broader ontological conversation. Identity helps explain recognizability and self-description; organizationality helps specify when a collective arrangement counts as organizational in the first place (Dobusch & Schoeneborn, 2015). But neither concept, on its own, resolves the question of what must be sustained for that arrangement to remain organizational over time. Viability is introduced precisely to mark that missing level.

4.2 Viability Is Not Performance, Success, or Mere Survival

A second clarification is equally important: viability is not reducible to performance or success. Organization theory has long evaluated organizations through the language of outcomes, effectiveness, adaptation, and goal attainment. If organizations are commonly judged in terms of how well they perform, it is easy to treat viability as a more abstract synonym for organizational success. But that move would collapse an ontological question into an evaluative one.

Performance concerns how well an organization produces desired outcomes relative to particular standards, which may vary across contexts, observers, and theoretical traditions (Thompson, 1967; Scott, 2003). Viability concerns something more basic: whether the

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organization continues to sustain the conditions under which organized existence remains possible. An organization may perform poorly while remaining viable, just as it may produce strong short-term outcomes while eroding the very conditions on which its continued existence depends. Performance and viability therefore do not move together.

This distinction also clarifies why viability cannot be reduced to success. Success is always indexed to some evaluative criterion: profitability, efficiency, innovation, social value, stakeholder satisfaction, or strategic goal attainment. Viability, by contrast, is not primarily about whether the organization is doing well by a given standard. It is about whether the organization remains capable of persisting as an organization at all. Questions of performance presuppose continued organizational existence; viability asks what makes that existence possible in the first place.

For the same reason, viability should not be confused with mere empirical survival. Survival, taken descriptively, means only that some entity continues to be observed over time. But the continued observability of a formal entity does not establish that the conditions of organized existence remain intact. Legal continuity, nominal continuity, or repeated activity may conceal structural hollowing. A formally surviving organization may persist as a shell, a label, or a thin administrative trace while no longer clearly sustaining the conditions required for organized persistence. Viability therefore sets a stricter standard than survival alone.

This distinction matters analytically because, without it, organizational weakness is too easily interpreted only in outcome terms. Theories of failure may identify missed targets, poor adaptation, or weak performance without clarifying whether the organization is struggling while remaining viable or whether it is losing the conditions of persistence altogether. Viability sharpens that difference. It asks not whether the organization is

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succeeding, but whether it is still reproducing the conditions required to remain organizational.

4.3 Viability Is Not Reducible to Legitimacy

A final distinction is necessary to avoid another consequential conflation: viability is not reducible to legitimacy. Legitimacy has long been treated as a central condition of organizational endurance because organizations require acceptance, authorization, trust, and social support to secure cooperation, access resources, and maintain standing in relevant environments (Suchman, 1995; Scott, 2003; Bitektine & Haack, 2015; Haack, Schilke, & Zucker, 2021). In many contexts, legitimacy is plainly important to continuity. But importance is not identity.

Legitimacy concerns the perceived appropriateness, desirability, or acceptability of an organization within socially constructed systems of norms, values, and expectations (Suchman, 1995). It explains why organizations are granted support, deference, or tolerance by relevant audiences. This is a major contribution to organization theory. But legitimacy remains a particular kind of condition: a condition of social authorization, not a complete specification of organizational persistence.

An organization may enjoy strong legitimacy while failing to sustain other conditions necessary for continued organized existence. Conversely, organizations may at times persist despite weak or contested legitimacy, relying on internal coordination, buffering, inertia, or partial insulation from external audiences. In both directions, the point is the same: legitimacy may support viability, but it does not exhaust it. Social recognition and organizational persistence are related without being equivalent.

This distinction becomes especially important where public endorsement can mask structural fragility. An organization may remain institutionally accepted and symbolically

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valued while becoming internally brittle, coordinatively degraded, or reproductively unsustainable. Treating legitimacy as interchangeable with viability would make such cases difficult to diagnose because social authorization would be mistaken for evidence that the underlying conditions of persistence remain intact.

For that reason, legitimacy is best understood here as an adjacent but non-equivalent construct. In many empirical settings, it may be one important dimension of viability. But the ontological question of viability must remain broader than any single neighboring concept. Viability asks what must be sustained for organizational persistence; legitimacy specifies one important mode of support through which such persistence may be enabled, constrained, or threatened.

Taken together, these distinctions clarify the conceptual space of the argument. Viability is not identity, because recognizability does not guarantee organized persistence. It is not performance or success, because favorable outcomes do not specify the conditions of organizational existence. It is not mere survival, because nominal continuity may outlast organized viability. And it is not legitimacy, because social authorization, however important, does not exhaust the structural requirements of persistence. The next section develops viability on its own terms by specifying a structural ontology of organizational persistence grounded in conditions of existence and a criterion of necessity.

5. A Structural Ontology of Viability

5.1 Conditions of Existence

If viability is to be treated as a distinct ontological problem, it must be specified in terms stronger than durability, continuity, or survival in a merely descriptive sense. The question cannot simply be whether organizations happen to continue through time, but what conditions must be in place for such continuity to count as the persistence of an organized

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collective rather than as the residual presence of a name, legal shell, or intermittent pattern of activity. This requires a shift from observable continuation to conditions of existence.

By conditions of existence, we mean the minimal structural conditions that must be sustained for an organization to continue existing as an organization over time. These are not empirical regularities, ideal characteristics, or desirable attributes. Nor are they whatever a particular theoretical tradition happens to emphasize. They refer, instead, to the conditions without which the phenomenon can no longer be said to persist as an organized collective in any meaningful sense. In that way, conditions of existence define the lower bound of organizational persistence.

This formulation matters because organization theory often moves quickly from variation to explanation. Theories explain differences in adaptation, coordination, legitimacy, structure, or outcomes across organizations, but such explanations generally presuppose that an organization exists to begin with (Scott, 2003; Thompson, 1967). Conditions of existence introduce a prior level of specification. They ask what must already be sustained such that the object of those explanations remains in place across time. Without such a baseline, analysis risks oscillating between rich accounts of organizational functioning and an under-explicated conception of the phenomenon whose functioning is being explained.

Importantly, this does not imply that all organizations instantiate those conditions in the same way. Organizations vary enormously in structure, scale, environment, and mode of coordination. But variation in form does not eliminate the need for a baseline of existence. If the field is to compare organizations, explain their variation, or distinguish fragility from non-existence, it must be able to identify a level at which persistence depends not on a particular design, but on the continued presence of conditions sufficiently fundamental to organized collective existence itself.

5.2 Criterion of Necessity

To specify such conditions without collapsing them into contingent organizational features, this paper adopts a criterion of necessity. The logic is simple: a condition counts as ontologically relevant to viability if its sustained absence implies the collapse of the phenomenon as an organization. Necessity, in this sense, does not mean ubiquity, desirability, or causal importance in every empirical setting. It means that without the condition in question, the phenomenon can no longer be said to persist as an organized collective over time.

This criterion is essential because organization theory contains many concepts that matter greatly to organizational life without all of them being ontological in the present sense. Many features may improve performance, support adaptation, enhance legitimacy, or stabilize coordination. Yet not every important feature is a condition of existence. Some are enabling, advantageous, or contextually indispensable without being necessary in the stronger sense required here. The criterion of necessity provides a way to distinguish conditions that are constitutive of organizational persistence from those that are merely contributory or contingent.

The value of this criterion is that it is discriminating rather than expansive. Its function is not to multiply ontological claims, but to constrain them. One danger in theoretical work of this kind is to overload the phenomenon with too many allegedly essential properties. The criterion of necessity pushes in the opposite direction. It asks only whether the phenomenon remains intelligible as a persisting organization when a given condition is removed. If it does, then the condition is not ontological in the sense intended here. If it does not, then the condition has a stronger claim to necessity.

This negative test is especially important in a field marked by empirical diversity. Organizations vary across sectors, technologies, institutional environments, and degrees of formalization. In such a field, necessity cannot be inferred from any single empirical form. It must instead be specified at a level abstract enough to travel across variation without becoming empty. What is being sought are not universal empirical traits, but structurally necessary conditions of persistence. This is why necessity must also be distinguished from normative ideals. To say that a condition is necessary for organizational viability is not to say that all organizations ought to maximize it or display it in a recognizable institutional form. It is to say that if the condition is not sustained in some functionally equivalent way, the organization cannot continue existing as an organization over time.

5.3 Why Necessity Matters for Organizational Ontology

The criterion of necessity matters because it shifts the ontological question from description to structure. Rather than asking what organizations typically look like, or enumerating the features commonly associated with organizational life, it asks a more demanding question: what cannot be absent if the phenomenon is still to count as an organization over time? This is the move that turns viability into a structural ontology rather than a descriptive catalogue.

In organization theory, ontological reflection has often been oriented toward questions of constitution, meaning, and form. These remain indispensable concerns. They clarify how organizations are recognized, how they become intelligible as social entities, and how they are distinguished from other collective arrangements (Scott, 2003; Tsoukas & Chia, 2002). But if ontology is also to address persistence, it cannot stop there. It must specify the conditions under which the phenomenon can continue existing as an organization rather than

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merely appearing as one at a given moment. Necessity provides the standard by which such conditions can be identified.

This is especially important in a plural field. Different theories highlight different dimensions of organizational life and often do so for good reasons. Some emphasize legitimacy, others adaptation, routines, identity, resources, or sensemaking. Without a criterion of necessity, however, ontological claims risk becoming inflated by proximity: features that are central to one explanatory lens can too easily be treated as indispensable to organizational existence as such. The criterion of necessity disciplines that tendency. It asks whether the phenomenon remains organizational in the absence of a given condition, not whether the condition is important within a favored theory.

For that reason, necessity gives the present argument its analytical force. Without it, viability would risk becoming another broad term for endurance, resilience, or continuity. With it, viability becomes a more precise ontological concept: the set of conditions that must be sustained for organizations to continue existing as organizations over time. This precision is what makes the present intervention theoretically meaningful. The point is not merely to name another concept, but to clarify a problem that existing concepts only partially capture and to do so in a way that strengthens theory building in the field (Cornelissen & Durand, 2014; Sutton & Staw, 1995).

A final implication follows directly. If viability concerns what must be sustained, and if necessity is the standard for identifying such conditions, then the next task is not to describe organizations exhaustively, but to derive the minimal conditions whose absence would undermine persistence. The following section takes up that task by specifying the lower-bound conditions required for organizational existence over time.

6. Deriving the Minimal Conditions of Organizational Persistence

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If viability concerns what must be sustained for organizations to continue existing over time, the next step is to identify the minimal conditions implied by that claim. These conditions are not introduced as a classificatory model or a managerial framework. They are derived from the problem of persistence itself. A temporally extended organization must, at minimum, be able to project itself across time, organize interdependent action, and realize that action in practice. Without those capacities, what remains may be collective activity, symbolic continuity, or episodic coordination, but not a persisting organization in the stronger sense developed here (Thompson, 1967; Scott, 2003; Tsoukas & Chia, 2002).

6.1 Temporal Orientation

The first minimal condition is temporal orientation. If organizations persist through time, they cannot be exhausted by coordinated activity in the present alone. They must sustain some capacity to orient present action toward future organizational continuation. Temporal orientation, in this sense, does not mean formal strategy, long-range planning, or elaborate forecasting. It refers more minimally to the fact that current activity must be structured in relation to continued existence over time.

This condition follows directly from the temporal character of the phenomenon. A collective that acts only in the immediacy of the present may still display interaction, coordination, or even short-term effectiveness, but it cannot be said to persist as an organization unless its activity is linked to some horizon of continuity beyond the moment (Tsoukas & Chia, 2002). To persist, an organization must remain capable of projecting itself forward, whether through formal plans, iterative anticipation, recurrent commitments, or more practical forms of future-directed orientation.

What matters, then, is not the empirical form of temporal orientation but its function. Organizations may vary widely in how explicitly they articulate the future. Some may do so

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strategically, others more tacitly through routines or practical expectations. But where no ongoing relation exists between present activity and future continuation, organized existence contracts into episodic action. Temporal orientation is therefore not a specialized managerial feature; it is a lower-bound condition of persistence.

6.2 Structured Coordination

Temporal orientation alone, however, is not sufficient. A collective may be future-oriented without yet being able to sustain itself as an organization. For persistence to occur, future-oriented activity must be translated into an organized arrangement of interdependent action. This is the second minimal condition: structured coordination.

By structured coordination, we mean the capacity to relate activities, actors, and commitments in a durable enough way that collective action acquires organizational form across time. The emphasis here is not on coordination in the thin sense of people merely acting together, but on coordination as an organized ordering of interdependence. Persistence cannot be achieved through isolated or parallel action alone. Even where participants share an orientation toward continuity, the collective does not yet persist as an organization unless action is linked in ways that stabilize relations among its parts (Thompson, 1967; Weick, Sutcliffe, & Obstfeld, 2005).

This condition should not be reduced to hierarchy, bureaucracy, or any single organizational design. Organizations may coordinate through roles, routines, protocols, mutual adjustment, digital interfaces, or other mechanisms. The ontological point is not that one form is required, but that some structured mediation of interdependence must be present. Without it, future-oriented activity remains dispersed: aspiration may exist, but organized persistence does not.

Structured coordination therefore marks the point at which temporal orientation becomes organizationally arranged. It gives continuity collective form. A future without coordinated interdependence is merely intention. For the organization to persist, that intention must be organized into relations that can be recurrently sustained.

6.3 Operational Enactment

Even temporal orientation and structured coordination together remain insufficient unless they are realized in practice. Organizations do not persist as intentions or arrangements alone. They persist only insofar as those orientations and coordinative structures are enacted through ongoing activity. This is the third minimal condition: operational enactment.

Operational enactment refers to the capacity to realize organized activity in concrete and recurrent practice. It is not a synonym for efficiency, nor does it refer only to frontline execution in a managerial sense. At the level of viability, it names the more basic requirement that organized existence be continuously brought into being through action. A collective may be future-oriented and coordinatively arranged, but if these remain largely unrealized, the organization does not reproduce itself over time. What remains is, at best, a projected or nominal organization rather than an ongoing organized accomplishment (Weick et al., 2005; Scott, 2003).

As with the previous conditions, enactment should not be tied to one empirical form. Different organizations enact themselves through different rhythms, practices, and operational repertoires. Some do so through routinized procedures, others through projects, cycles, experiments, or professional judgment. The claim is not that organizations must enact themselves in the same way, but that they must remain capable of enactment at all. Persistence depends not on a specific operating model, but on the recurrent realization of organized activity in practice.

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Operational enactment also completes the logic of the prior two conditions. Temporal orientation links present activity to future continuation. Structured coordination gives that continuity collective form. Operational enactment realizes both in practice. Without enactment, orientation remains aspirational and coordination remains formal. The organization may still exist symbolically or administratively, but not as a persisting organized phenomenon.

Taken together, these three conditions define a minimal lower bound for organizational persistence. If organizations are to continue existing over time, they must remain capable of orienting activity toward continued existence, coordinating interdependence in durable form, and enacting organized activity in practice. Negative-case reasoning makes the derivation clearer: orientation without coordination yields intention without organization; coordination without enactment yields arrangement without reproduction; enactment without temporal continuity yields activity without persistence. The argument is therefore not that these conditions describe all organizational complexity, but that they specify what cannot be absent if the phenomenon is still to count as a persisting organization. The next section draws the temporal implication of this claim: if these conditions must be sustained, they must also be continuously reproduced over time.

7. From Conditions to Reproduction over Time

7.1 Why Conditions Must Be Reproduced

If the preceding argument is correct, then organizational persistence depends on the continued presence of certain minimal conditions: temporal orientation, structured coordination, and operational enactment. But to identify such conditions is not yet enough. A further implication follows immediately: if these conditions are necessary for persistence,

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they cannot be treated as once-established foundations that simply remain in place by inertia. They must be continuously reproduced over time.

This follows from the temporal character of the phenomenon itself. Organizations are not static entities whose existence is secured once and then merely prolonged. They are temporally extended collectivities whose continued existence depends on recurrent activity, ongoing alignment, and the renewal of the conditions that make organized persistence possible (Tsoukas & Chia, 2002). To say that an organization persists is already to say that the conditions of its persistence do not merely exist at one moment, but are sustained across moments. Persistence is therefore not passive endurance; it is the ongoing reproduction of a structured possibility of continued existence.

This is why viability cannot be understood as a static property. It is not something an organization simply possesses, like a formal designation or a durable trait. Nor is it exhausted by the fact that the organization currently appears coordinated, future-oriented, or operationally active. Viability is dynamic in a basic but important sense: the conditions underlying it must be recurrently maintained. An organization is viable not because it once established the requisites of persistence, but because it continues to reproduce them under changing circumstances.

The need for reproduction becomes clearer once one considers how easily organizational conditions can degrade. Temporal orientation can collapse into short-term reaction. Structured coordination can fragment into unstable interdependence. Operational enactment can weaken into nominal or suspended activity. None of these failures requires the immediate disappearance of the organization in a visible sense. A collective may still have a name, formal status, or recognizable surface. Yet its persistence may already depend on

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reserves of effort, legitimacy, or memory that are no longer being adequately renewed.

Reproduction names this problem of maintenance rather than inheritance.

Importantly, reproduction here does not mean exact repetition or preservation of an unchanged form. Organizations may reproduce the conditions of their persistence while altering structures, practices, identities, or operating modes. Reproduction is therefore compatible with transformation. The point is not that organizations endure by remaining the same, but that even change presupposes some recurrent renewal of the conditions without which organized existence would no longer be possible (Tsoukas & Chia, 2002).

Reproduction is thus the temporal implication of viability: if viability specifies what must be sustained, reproduction names the ongoing process through which such sustenance occurs.

7.2 Reproduction as a Problem of Functioning

Once persistence is understood as dependent on the continuous reproduction of viability conditions, the argument must move from ontology to functioning. This is not a departure from the ontological problem, but its necessary continuation. If viability specifies what must be sustained for organizations to persist, functioning concerns how those conditions are recurrently enacted, maintained, and renewed over time.

This transition matters because ontological conditions do not reproduce themselves. To identify temporal orientation, structured coordination, and operational enactment as necessary conditions of persistence is to establish what viability requires. But such conditions remain inert unless they are carried forward through organized activity. Future orientation must be sustained in practice; interdependence must be recurrently organized; enacted activity must continue to realize organizational existence. Reproduction therefore becomes a problem of functioning.

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Functioning, as used here, should be understood broadly. It does not refer only to efficiency, productivity, or the successful execution of formal tasks. Nor does it imply a fixed managerial repertoire. It refers to the organized ways in which the conditions of persistence are sustained across time. In that sense, functioning is the domain in which ontological requirements become temporally operative. If viability is about what must exist, functioning is about how that existence remains organizationally possible over time (Weick, Sutcliffe, & Obstfeld, 2005).

This is an important intermediate step in the paper's argument. Before one can specify a grammar of organizational reproduction, one must first recognize that reproduction is itself a problem of functioning. Organizations do not persist through pure ontology, and they do not persist through isolated acts. They persist through organized modes of functioning that recurrently sustain the conditions of viability. These modes may vary across organizations and contexts, but the underlying point remains: persistence requires reproduction, and reproduction is achieved through functioning.

This also clarifies why grammar enters only later. If the reproduction of viability conditions depends on functioning, and if that functioning is not arbitrary, then a further question arises: what structures the recurrent maintenance of those conditions? That question opens the way to grammar, but only after the present step has been secured. The contribution of this section is therefore modest but essential. It establishes that viability implies reproduction, and that reproduction is not merely continuity in the abstract, but a problem of organized functioning. The next section takes that final step and asks what kind of patterned order is implied once the reproduction of viability conditions is treated as a recurrent organizational accomplishment.

8. From Reproduction to Grammar

8.1 Grammar in the Field

The idea of grammar is not foreign to organization theory. On the contrary, the field has long recognized that organizational activity is not random, but patterned by recurrent principles that give action a degree of order, intelligibility, and reproducibility. In particular, research on routines and process has shown that repeated action often exhibits a generative structure: actors do not simply replicate identical behaviors, but enact recognizable patterns that persist despite local variation in performance (Pentland & Rueter, 1994; Feldman & Pentland, 2003). In this literature, grammar functions as a way of conceptualizing the patterned organization of action.

This contribution was important because it made it possible to think about organizational order without collapsing it into either rigid determinism or unstructured improvisation. A grammatical view of action shows how organizations can sustain patterned repetition while remaining open to adaptation and change. It explains how routines can be both stable and generative, and how organizational order can be reproduced through recognizable but non-identical performances. Grammar, in that sense, already belongs to the field.

At the same time, existing grammatical approaches have usually been applied at a more localized analytical level than the one pursued here. Their central concern has been the patterned organization of routines, actions, or recurrent performances. The issue in the present argument is different. It is not only how action is patterned, but how the conditions of organizational persistence are recurrently reproduced over time. This does not displace prior grammatical work. It relocates grammar within a different theoretical sequence.

8.2 Grammar after Viability

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Once viability is distinguished as a specific ontological problem of persistence, the meaning of grammar shifts in an important way. Grammar no longer refers primarily to the patterned structure of localized action. Instead, it can be understood more fundamentally as the structured reproduction of the conditions that make organizational persistence possible. Put differently, if viability specifies what must be sustained, grammar concerns how the reproduction of those conditions is organized.

This repositioning matters because it places grammar in the correct analytical order. Without a prior specification of viability, grammar risks becoming conceptually overextended. It can too easily be treated as a total theory of organization, a substitute ontology, or a universal architecture of order. The present paper avoids that move. Grammar is introduced here not as the starting point of organizational theory, but as the downstream implication of a prior argument about persistence. Only once the conditions of viability have been specified does it become meaningful to ask how their reproduction is structured.

This is the point at which grammar becomes theoretically necessary. The argument has shown that organizations persist only insofar as certain minimal conditions are sustained, and that those conditions must be continuously reproduced through functioning over time. At that point, a further question becomes unavoidable: what structures the reproduction of those conditions such that it is not arbitrary? Grammar enters as the answer to that question. It names the patterned organization of reproduction itself.

To speak of grammar after viability is therefore to speak of generative constraints on reproduction. The claim is not that every organization follows an identical script, nor that organizational life can be reduced to one fixed sequence of practices. The claim is narrower: if viability conditions must be continuously sustained, then their reproduction must occur under some structured relations of admissibility, linkage, interdependence, or order. Without

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such structure, reproduction would collapse into arbitrariness, and organizational persistence would become theoretically opaque.

This is also why grammar, in the present argument, should be distinguished from empirical vocabulary. Organizations may differ widely in the routines, procedures, rituals, or devices through which they reproduce the conditions of persistence. Those concrete enactments may be historically variable and context-sensitive. What grammar seeks to capture is not that full surface diversity, but the more abstract organization of reproduction that underlies it. In this sense, grammar remains more general than routine and more downstream than ontology. It is the patterned organization through which viability conditions are recurrently maintained.

8.3 What This Paper Does Not Yet Specify

Placing grammar after viability also requires a clear statement of scope. This paper does not claim to have fully specified the substantive or technical content of organizational grammar. To do so would require a different kind of contribution—one concerned with the fuller articulation of the patterned mechanisms through which viability conditions are reproduced across organizational settings. The present argument stops short of that stronger claim.

That limitation is deliberate. The purpose of this paper is to identify a missing level in organization theory by distinguishing viability as a distinct ontological problem, deriving the minimal conditions of persistence, and showing why their reproduction cannot be treated as unstructured. Grammar enters only as the logical consequence of that argument. Once viability conditions are identified, their reproduction must be patterned in some way. But that does not yet amount to a complete grammatical architecture.

This clarification is important because it protects the paper from a common misreading. A paper that invokes grammar can easily be read as if it were already proposing a complete organizational system. That is not the claim here. The present argument remains one step earlier. It establishes why the field needs a grammatical layer once viability has been specified, but it does not attempt to close that space by prematurely filling in its entire content.

For the same reason, this paper does not reduce grammar to one universal organizational design, nor does it claim that prior work on routines and patterned action is insufficient on its own terms. Its claim is narrower and more precise: grammar has not yet been adequately positioned as the patterned reproduction of viability conditions derived from an explicit ontology of persistence. That is the contribution made here. With this sequence in place, the paper can now turn to its broader implications for organization theory.

9. Implications for Organization Theory

9.1 Analytical Clarity

A first implication of distinguishing viability as a distinct ontological problem is greater analytical clarity within organization theory. Much of the field's richness has come from the development of specialized vocabularies—identity, legitimacy, routines, institutions, adaptation, sensemaking, and performance, among others (Scott, 2003; Davis, 2010). This pluralism has been productive, but it has also encouraged a tendency for different kinds of questions to be addressed in overlapping terms. As a result, issues of constitution, recognition, persistence, functioning, and evaluation are often brought into proximity without being clearly separated at the level of analysis.

The distinction developed here helps clarify those levels. Identity concerns what organizations are and how they become recognizable as meaningful entities.

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Organizationality concerns when a collective arrangement crosses the threshold into organizational status (Dobusch & Schoeneborn, 2015). Viability concerns what must be sustained for that arrangement to remain organizational over time. Grammar, finally, concerns the patterned reproduction of those conditions once viability has been specified. These questions are related, but they are not interchangeable.

This clarification matters because many apparent disagreements in organization theory may reflect differences in the problem being addressed rather than substantive incompatibility. A theory of legitimacy may explain how external support is maintained; a routines perspective may explain how patterned activity is reproduced; a performance perspective may evaluate outcomes relative to goals; an identity perspective may clarify how continuity of self-description is sustained. Each may be theoretically valuable without operating at the same analytical level. Distinguishing viability therefore does not add another broad concept to an already crowded field. It disciplines the use of existing ones by clarifying which problem each addresses and why that difference matters for theory building (Cornelissen & Durand, 2014; Sandberg & Alvesson, 2021).

9.2 Comparability

A second implication is a stronger basis for comparability across organizational forms and theoretical traditions. Organization theory has long faced the problem of heterogeneity: organizations differ dramatically in purpose, scale, formalization, institutional environment, and mode of coordination (Scott, 2003; Davis, 2010). Such diversity makes comparison necessary but difficult. In practice, organizations are often compared in terms of outcomes, structures, legitimacy, or strategic choices. These are useful dimensions, but they do not necessarily clarify whether the cases being compared are equivalent at the level of organizational persistence itself.

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A viability perspective introduces a more explicit lower bound. It asks whether the conditions necessary for organizational persistence are being sustained, and if so, in what forms and through what vulnerabilities. This does not flatten empirical variation. On the contrary, it makes variation more intelligible by distinguishing between alternative ways of sustaining persistence and forms of deterioration that threaten persistence itself. Two organizations may differ substantially in performance or institutional form while both remaining viable; another may resemble them superficially while already losing the conditions required for continued existence.

This baseline is especially useful in a field increasingly concerned with fluid, partial, and nontraditional forms of organizing. In such cases, familiar indicators of formal organization—stable hierarchy, durable membership, fixed boundaries—may not be consistently present. Viability provides another route to comparison. Instead of asking whether a phenomenon resembles the conventional organization, one can ask whether and how it sustains the conditions required for organizational persistence. In that sense, viability creates a more portable comparative baseline without imposing uniformity on the empirical world.

9.3 Failure versus Non-Existence

A third implication is that the distinction sharpens the boundary between organizational failure and the absence of organization. This boundary is often blurred because weak performance, instability, fragmentation, or declining legitimacy are frequently treated as if they all describe the same phenomenon: organizations functioning badly. Yet not all forms of breakdown are of the same kind. Some indicate dysfunction within a still-viable organization; others indicate that the conditions required for persistence are no longer being sustained.

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This distinction matters because the language of failure is usually evaluative rather than ontological. An organization may fail to achieve its goals, adapt effectively, coordinate well, or maintain legitimacy while still remaining an organization in the stronger sense of continued organized existence. In such cases, the organization is dysfunctional, but viable. Conversely, a collective may retain its name, legal designation, symbolic identity, or intermittent activity while no longer sustaining temporal orientation, structured coordination, or operational enactment in a way that reproduces organized existence over time. In such cases, the problem is not merely that the organization is failing. The problem is that the phenomenon may no longer persist as an organization at all.

Viability makes this difference more visible. It allows theory to distinguish a weak organization from one that has crossed into ontological fragility. That distinction is especially important where legal continuity or symbolic recognition can outlast structural integrity. Without an explicit concept of viability, such cases are too easily collapsed under a generic vocabulary of decline. With it, the field gains a sharper basis for diagnosing fragility, erosion, and collapse.

9.4 Interoperability and Future Research

A fourth implication is greater interoperability across theoretical traditions. Organization theory is not a unified paradigm but a plural field composed of partially overlapping questions, mechanisms, and explanatory styles (Scott, 2003; Davis, 2010). This pluralism is a strength, but it also creates a recurring problem: theories often appear to speak past one another because they address different levels of the phenomenon without clearly marking those differences. A viability baseline helps mitigate this problem by providing a common reference point beneath theoretical diversity.

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The value of such a baseline lies not in replacing existing theories, but in situating them more precisely. Identity research can be understood as addressing recognizability and continuity of self-description. Legitimacy research can be understood as addressing social authorization and support. Routines and process perspectives can be understood as illuminating patterned reproduction in practice. Performance-oriented work can be understood as evaluating outcomes relative to goals or standards. Viability adds a lower-bound problem to which each may relate differently: what must be sustained for organizations to persist as organizations over time. This helps reorganize the theoretical landscape without suppressing pluralism.

It also opens several avenues for future research. One concerns the refinement and contestation of the minimal conditions derived here. Another concerns diagnosis: if viability defines a threshold of persistence, scholars can ask how fragility, erosion, and collapse should be understood once that threshold is made explicit. A third concerns grammar more directly. If viability conditions must be reproduced through functioning, then future work can investigate the patterned structures through which such reproduction occurs, without prematurely assuming a single finalized architecture. A fourth concerns the relationship between viability and neighboring constructs: under what conditions does legitimacy become indispensable to viability? When does identity stabilize persistence, and when does it merely preserve recognizability after structural erosion has begun?

In this sense, distinguishing viability does more than solve a local conceptual problem. It reorganizes the architecture of theorizing by identifying a lower-bound issue that many perspectives presuppose but do not always name. That is why the contribution is both substantive and infrastructural. It clarifies a missing level of analysis while opening a research agenda on persistence, diagnosis, fragility, collapse, and the grammatical organization of

reproduction. The final sections therefore delimit the scope of this argument, clarify its non-claims, and specify the conditions under which it could be challenged.

10. Scope Conditions, Non-Claims, and Refutability

10.1 Scope Conditions

The argument developed here applies to organizations understood as temporally extended collectivities whose continued existence depends on the recurrent organization of activity over time (Tsoukas & Chia, 2002). This scope condition matters because the concept of viability is not intended to cover every form of collective action, coordination, or social aggregation. The paper is concerned specifically with phenomena that can meaningfully be described as persisting organizations, rather than as momentary episodes of cooperation, transient gatherings, or weakly organized social formations without sustained continuation.

This restriction follows directly from the problem under consideration. Viability concerns what must be sustained for organizations to continue existing as organizations over time. The argument therefore presupposes a temporal horizon in which persistence is itself intelligible as an analytical issue. If a collective arrangement is so brief, episodic, or discontinuous that no question of continued organizational existence meaningfully arises, then the problem of viability is not fully applicable. In such cases, the more relevant question may be organizationality—whether something counts as organizational at all—rather than viability as a condition of endurance.

The argument is also not concerned with mere legal or nominal continuity. An entity may survive on paper, remain formally registered, or retain a recognizable name while no longer reproducing the conditions of organized persistence. Such cases matter precisely because they illuminate the distinction advanced here: the object of analysis is organized persistence, not formal persistence alone. The framework is therefore broad enough to travel

across heterogeneous organizational forms, but selective enough to exclude collectivities for which continued organizational existence is not yet, or no longer, the issue at stake.

10.2 Non-Claims

To prevent overextended readings, it is equally important to clarify what this paper does not claim. First, it does not propose a final descriptive essence of organization. The argument is not that organizations “really are” viability, nor that existing ontological approaches should be replaced by a single master definition. The claim is narrower: viability is a distinct ontological problem concerning organizational persistence.

Second, the paper does not offer a universal model of organizational design. The conditions derived here—temporal orientation, structured coordination, and operational enactment—are not a blueprint for how organizations should be built or governed. They identify a lower bound of persistence, not an optimal architecture.

Third, the paper does not reduce viability to effectiveness, performance, or success. It is not a performance theory, and it does not claim that viable organizations are necessarily efficient, resilient, or normatively desirable. Its concern is more basic: whether the conditions of organized existence continue to be sustained.

Fourth, the paper does not reduce persistence to any single neighboring construct such as identity, legitimacy, adaptation, or survival. These remain important concepts in organization theory. The present argument is differentiating rather than subsumptive: it clarifies a missing level without absorbing the rest of the field into it.

Fifth, the paper does not claim that the full grammar of organizational persistence has been specified here. Grammar is introduced only as the patterned reproduction of viability conditions once those conditions have been clarified. A fuller grammatical architecture remains a task for later development.

Finally, the paper does not claim that the three minimal conditions derived here are beyond revision. They are proposed as a theoretically derived lower bound under the criterion of necessity advanced in this article. Future work may refine, extend, challenge, or re-specify them. That openness is a strength rather than a weakness. As Sutton and Staw (1995) remind us, theoretical work gains force not by pretending to be exhaustive, but by clarifying the problem it actually solves.

10.3 Refutability

The argument advanced here is ontological, but it is not intended to be insulated from challenge. On the contrary, distinguishing viability as a specific problem of organizational persistence makes the argument more vulnerable to disciplined critique, not less. The most direct route of challenge would be to show that organizations can persist over time as organizations without sustaining the kinds of conditions identified here. If temporally extended organizations remain organizationally persistent despite the sustained absence of temporal orientation, structured coordination, or operational enactment in any functionally equivalent form, then the necessity claim advanced in this paper would be weakened.

A second route of challenge would be to show that viability is not analytically distinct after all. If it could be demonstrated that organizationality or identity already fully contains an account of what must be sustained for persistence, then the distinction proposed here would become redundant rather than clarifying.

A third route of challenge would concern the criterion of necessity itself. One might argue that organizational persistence cannot be specified through necessary conditions without becoming either too abstract to discriminate meaningful cases or too rigid to accommodate empirical diversity. In that case, the structural ontology proposed here would require revision.

These possibilities mean that the argument should be understood as disciplined revisability, not conceptual insulation. The wager of the paper is that organization theory gains precision by distinguishing viability from adjacent concerns and by grounding persistence in necessary conditions whose reproduction points toward grammar. If that wager proves mistaken, the field will need a better way of specifying the lower bound of organizational persistence. With these limits now made explicit, the paper can conclude by restating its central contribution and significance.

11. Conclusion

This paper has argued that organization theory has under-specified a distinct ontological problem of persistence. The field has developed increasingly sophisticated ways of explaining what organizations are, when collective arrangements count as organizational, and how organizations vary in form, functioning, and outcomes. What has remained less clearly isolated is a more basic question: what must be sustained for organizations to continue existing as organizations over time? The central contribution of the paper has been to name that problem viability and to argue that it should be treated as its own level of ontological inquiry.

The significance of this distinction is not merely terminological. By separating identity, organizationality, and viability, the paper clarifies different questions that organization theory has often allowed to drift together. Identity concerns what organizations are and how they remain recognizable as meaningful entities. Organizationality concerns when a collective arrangement crosses the threshold into organizational status. Viability concerns what must be sustained for that arrangement to remain organizational through time. Without this distinction, organization theory risks conflating recognizability, threshold status,

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performance, legitimacy, and persistence within a single and overly elastic language of continuity.

To address this problem, the paper developed a structural ontology of viability grounded in conditions of existence and a criterion of necessity. From that basis, it derived three minimal conditions of organizational persistence: temporal orientation, structured coordination, and operational enactment. These are not offered as a complete theory of organization or as a universal design model. They are proposed as a lower bound: the minimal conditions that cannot be absent if a phenomenon is still to count as a persisting organization. The paper then drew the temporal implication of that claim: if such conditions must be sustained, they must also be reproduced. From there, it positioned grammar not as an alternative ontology or full system, but as the patterned organization of that reproduction.

What this opens for the field is a more explicit basis for diagnosis and comparison. Distinguishing viability sharpens the difference between organizational failure and ontological breakdown, provides a lower-bound baseline for comparing heterogeneous organizational forms, and helps different theoretical traditions relate to one another without collapsing pluralism into a single framework. In that sense, the argument is both corrective and generative: corrective because it identifies a missing level in the field's conceptual architecture, generative because it opens a research agenda around persistence, fragility, erosion, collapse, and the grammatical organization of reproduction.

The paper has deliberately stopped short of specifying a full grammar of organizational persistence. That remains a task for later development. But the present argument establishes why such a task becomes meaningful only after viability has been distinguished as a problem in its own right. If this argument is correct, then organization theory has not simply overlooked another concept. It has under-specified a necessary level of

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inquiry. The ontological question in organization theory is therefore not exhausted by asking what organizations are. It must also ask what must structurally be sustained for them to continue being at all.

AI Use Disclosure

AI tools were used under the author's direction for drafting and language refinement during manuscript development. All conceptual claims, theoretical argumentation, interpretive decisions, and the final text were reviewed, revised, and approved by the author, who retains full responsibility for the manuscript.

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Table I. Distinguishing identity, organizationality, viability, and grammar

Level of inquiry	Core question	Primary analytical focus	What it helps explain	Limitation relative to the present argument	Function in this paper
Identity	What are organizations?	Constitution, meaning, recognizability, and continuity of organizational self-understanding	How organizations are defined, narrated, and rendered intelligible as social entities	Does not specify what must be structurally sustained for organizations to persist over time	Important background conversation
Organizationality	When does something count as an organization?	The condition or degree of becoming organizational, especially in fluid, partial, or emergent forms	How collective arrangements come to acquire organizational character	Clarifies organizational constitution, but not the minimal conditions required for enduring persistence	Adjacent conversation
Viability	What must be sustained for organizations to persist over time?	Conditions of persistence and continued organized existence	What makes enduring organizational existence possible across changing forms and contexts	Has not been clearly isolated as a distinct ontological problem of persistence	Core contribution of this paper
Grammar	How are the conditions of viability recurrently enacted and reproduced?	Structured reproduction of organizational conditions over time	How persistent organization is sustained through patterned modes of functioning	Does not itself define the ontological conditions of existence	Downstream implication of the argument